fashion, and leaning neither to the right nor the left. If ever I achieved that vertical stance, it was only a momentary one as my rifle

shifted from a left-leaning slant to a right-leaning one or vice versa. Nor did I march briskly. After about a quarter of a mile, I drooped and dragged.

I never even learned how to salute with the proper snap.

Yet none of this ever drew upon me a reprimand. Not once was I ordered off to be hung, or even just to be strung up by my left big toe. Noncoms and minor officers passed me by to bark at some soldier on the other side of me who, as nearly as I could tell, was a model of military deportment in comparison to me. Nor did anyone ever make any adverse comment to me after looking through my rifle barrel, even though it seemed to me, as I watched tensely, that I could clearly see rust drizzling down into the officerial eye.

Many months later, a friendly lieutenant told me that the commanding officer, before basic had begun, had gone over the soldiers with his subordinates and had said concerning me, something as follows: 3

"Now this guy Asimov you might as well leave alone. He's got a 160 AGCT score and they ain't going to use him anywhere except behind a desk so don't waste time on him. He's the kind of stupe that's okay on those shit tests, but he don't know his right foot from his left and there ain't no use trying to teach him because he ain't got any sense. I been watching and I can see that."

After that I was ignored by every officer and noncom in the place.

When I found this out, I was indignant beyond words. Not, you understand, that I quarreled with the commanding officer's opinion of me, which I thought was accurate enough and a credit to his perspicacity. What graveled me was that no one was kind enough to whisper the news to me so that I could relax. I would gladly have agreed to have continued to do my best to make beds, clean rifles, and march, but why should I not have done it with a song in my heart?

6

If I thought I did poorly on bed make-up and rifle cleaning, I hit new depths of degradation on the physical-conditioning test, held on November 27. It was the physical version of the AGCT score and again I managed to make the extreme. I was best in the company (maybe in the Army) in AGCT and worst